



A MAN wears a mask Saturday as a Boyle Heights warehouse fire sends smoke cascading across the region.

## MAYOR DECLARES FIRE A 'MAJOR' INCIDENT

Bass issues a state of emergency as smoke from blaze in Boyle Heights spreads.

By HAYLEY SMITH AND LAURENCE DARMIENTO

L.A. city officials on Saturday declared a local emergency as firefighters continue to battle a stubborn warehouse fire in Boyle Heights that has sent plumes of irritating smoke across the region.

"While the [Los Angeles Fire Department] continues making progress, this is a major, multi-jurisdictional incident," Mayor Karen Bass said in a statement. "I'm issuing an emergency declaration to ensure the city has the resources it needs as this operation continues and to keep the community safe."

The declaration activates the city's emergency response structure, directs departments to assess damages and costs, and requests state assistance to support firefighting, cleanup, environmental monitoring and community recovery efforts.

Los Angeles Fire Department Chief Jamie Moore at a news conference Saturday described the blaze that broke out Wednesday as a "very unique fire, a very unique challenge for the Los Angeles Fire Department, for the city of Los Angeles, but also for the County of Los Angeles."

The 500,000-square-foot commercial building at 1400 S. Los Palos St. stores 85 million [See **Emergency**, A7]

## An embrace of MAGA across Latin America

To Trump's benefit, more in the region identify with the right than at any time in last two decades

By Ana Ceballos and Kate Linthicum

WASHINGTON — Colombian presidential candidate Abelardo de la Espriella has vowed to crush criminal groups and slash government programs. He promises to bomb "narco-terrorist" camps and build sprawling mega prisons if he wins Sunday's runoff election.

De la Espriella's views have earned him the vociferous backing of President Trump, who has broken with White House tradition by publicly seeking to tip the scales in foreign elections — particularly in Latin America.

After Trump gave his "complete and total endorsement" to De la Espriella, whom he referred to by his nickname, "El Tigre," the candidate posted an AI-generated image of a bald eagle and a tiger, with American and Colombian flags waving side by side.

"You have paved the way for the people to defeat the entrenched powers that have long held sway," he wrote to Trump. "In Colombia, we have now begun to follow the same path."

De la Espriella, a political newcomer who built his campaign around gym workout videos and vows to "disembowel" the left, is part of a new wave of far-right, MAGA-aligned politicians in Latin America openly borrowing from Trump's playbook, presenting themselves as outsiders who will trim the government, curtail immigration and militarize law enforcement.

In a region that remains plagued by high crime and inequality after a decades-long period of leftist domination known as the "Pink Tide," the playbook [See **Latin America**, A4]

## Real estate partnership sours, shaking sleepy Laguna Beach

Feds charged one from joint venture with bank fraud

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

When Laguna Beach real estate mogul Mohammad Honarkar got into financial trouble during the pandemic, he turned to a local investor for help — but it didn't turn out as he planned.

The joint venture he formed with the investor soon collapsed. Amid the fallout, Honarkar lost possession of most of his properties, including the historic Hotel Laguna, where a public scuffle had broken out in

2023 between his security team and guards working for the partner who wrested control of the landmark.

Three years later, Honarkar is claiming vindication after winning a \$1.34-billion arbitration award against the investor, Mahender Makhijani, 44, of Corona del Mar, who was arrested June 10 by federal authorities for alleged bank fraud involving a \$100-million loan default.

Makhijani was in custody last week and is due to enter a plea July 6. His criminal defense attorneys declined to comment last week.

The high-profile Laguna Beach business dispute has roiled the affluent seaside community, where Honarkar owned an area portfolio that included hotels, shops, restaurants and vacation rentals that were taken over by Makhijani and his associates in what Honarkar's attorneys have described as one of the largest commercial real estate scandals in Southern California history.

"I don't recall anything like that ever happening where people felt the need for armed guards in a dozen [See **Real estate**, A12]

## Newsom faces a renewed test on data centers

Thorny issue pins him between angry public and donors as he eyes 2028 presidential run.

By KATIE KING

SACRAMENTO — Gov. Gavin Newsom last year vetoed legislation to require proposed data centers to provide estimates of their water usage, saying he was "reluctant to impose rigid reporting requirements" without understanding the effect on businesses and consumers.

Opposition to the mammoth tech hubs and their massive thirst of water, power and land has only escalated throughout the state and nation ever since. In just a matter of months, Newsom could again find himself in the political crosshairs.

Several bills to regulate the facilities and increase public transparency on their impact are progressing in the California Legislature, which could create a conundrum for a governor who has long aligned with the tech industry but also paints himself as an environmental and social justice advocate.

"I think the governor is in a fragile position," said Megan Mullin, a public policy professor at UCLA. "Tech has been a longbacker of his, but at the same time there is this growing national outcry against data centers."

Data centers have existed for decades but are rapidly expanding due to the worldwide boom in artificial intelligence. The newer centers built to power AI are far larger than their original counterparts and require immense amounts of water and energy.

The facilities also contribute to fossil fuel emissions, with Cornell University researchers estimating last year that AI growth could add 24 million to 44 million metric tons of carbon dioxide to the atmosphere annually by 2030. Fossil fuel emissions are drivers of climate change and linked to a range of health conditions, including asthma, various cancers and birth defects.

Environmental Protection Agency Administrator Lee Zeldin announced last week that the Trump administration will not set national environmental requirements or recommendations for the data [See **Centers**, A7]

## Cuba pushes major free-market reform

The shift comes amid a tightened U.S. embargo of the communist island.

By ANDREA RODRÍGUEZ

HAVANA — Observers are calling Cuba's new free-market reforms the most sweeping economic overhaul of the island's communist economy since the Cuban revolution, as the grandson of former President Raúl Castro said in an interview that Cuba must seek to move its economy forward.

Cuba's Communist Party approved 176 measures Thursday as part of an emergency economic package, which was submitted to the National Assembly, where it is nearly certain to be approved.

The package aims to further decentralize Cuba's state-run economy, which has been left gasping by the Trump administration's tightened embargo. Under the island's current economic model, the government largely determines what is produced, who produces it, the prices at which goods are sold and how the country's resources are allocated.

The plan includes more space for private businesses, imports and exports without state intermediation, free hiring of personnel, authorization for private banks and investment by Cubans abroad. It even permits fast-food chains to establish themselves on the island.

"Elements that for decades were listed as pillars of the revolutionary economy, such as the state monopoly on foreign trade and the centralization of productive [See **Cuba**, A4]

## California pier becomes a climate battlefield

Pacifica looks to rebuild infrastructure, but does investing make sense?

By SUSANNE RUST

As a historic El Niño supercharges the Pacific Ocean and San Francisco experiences record-high seasonal sea levels, the latest structural casualty of intense wave action is prompting Bay Area politicians to call for help from the state and federal governments.

They want to rebuild a concrete pier shut down this month after officials deemed it unsafe because of cracking from decades of pounding surf and storms.

As waves crashed against



A WORKER moves boulders to be used to secure a heavily damaged portion of the Pacifica Pier.

the derelict structure Monday morning, U.S. Rep. Sam Liccardo (D-San José) held a news conference and asked the federal government to follow through on \$50 million in climate resilience funding promised by the Biden administration but terminated by the Trump administration in 2025.

The city of Pacifica had been on the shortlist for the Building Resilient Infrastructure and Communities program, managed through FEMA. California and 22 other states successfully sued to reinstate the pro- [See **Pier**, A8]



ANDREW CULLEN For The Times

### LAND OF GIANT TREES

Humboldt County is full of treasures beyond its natural ones, including Redwood National and State Parks. A guide to exploring. **WEEKEND, L6**

### Iran again closes Strait of Hormuz

The move on the eve of talks with U.S. comes in response to Israel's continued attacks in Lebanon. **WORLD, A3**

**Weather**  
Partly sunny.  
L.A. Basin: 75/61. **B8**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

### FDA panel backs mRNA flu shot

The first-of-its-kind vaccine for people over 50 uses the technology deployed in COVID-19 shots. **NATION, A6**

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